

IN REEL LIFE

Cinematic narratives have often employed trains to twist and turn a plot, writing them into the very grammar of the movies. They star in girl-meet-boy romances, are seen in movie montages, provide edge-of-the-seat action, and signal a change of place, time, and pace.



▲ **The motif of trains** is quite common in many Indian films. Scenes are often re-created from stations and passenger coaches. Seen here is a still from the Hindi film *Swades* (2004) starring Shah Rukh Khan.

Before making their debut on reel, trains were synonymous with speed, enterprise, and modernity, and came to motion pictures imbued with meaning. As Indian author and journalist Jerry Pinto wrote in an essay